R-Peak Detection in ECG Using Wavelet Transform and K-Means Clustering

María Isabel Sánchez-O'Mullony Martínez

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1 Introduction

This report describes the design and implementation of an R-peak detection algorithm for electrocardiogram (ECG) signals.

R-peak detection is a well-studied problem, and numerous methods have been proposed in the literature. A comprehensive review by H. Dogan and R. O. Dogan (2023) [1] surveys the most prominent techniques and evaluates their relative performance.

Following a thorough review of existing approaches, the method proposed by Xia et al. (2015) [2] was selected as the foundation for this implementation and subsequently extended. The pipeline consists of three main stages: a wavelet-based preprocessing stage that enhances QRS complexes, computation of an absolute-slope feature to capture rapid signal changes, and segmented K-means clustering to identify QRS regions. R-peaks are then extracted as local maxima within each identified region, followed by a refractory filter consistent with physiological heart-rate limits.

Wavelet transforms are widely used for R-peak detection due to their ability to localise signal features in both time and frequency. When combined with K-means clustering, this approach is computationally efficient, straightforward to implement, and robust to noise, achieving a reported accuracy of approximately 99.7%.

The implementation was evaluated on the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database [3], consistent with the original paper.

2 R-Peaks

A typical ECG signal comprises three principal segments: the P-wave, the QRS complex, and the T-wave. Each segment reflects a distinct phase of cardiac electrical activity and provides clinically valuable information about the state of the cardiovascular system.

The QRS complex is the most diagnostically significant segment, corresponding to the depolarisation of the right and left ventricles.

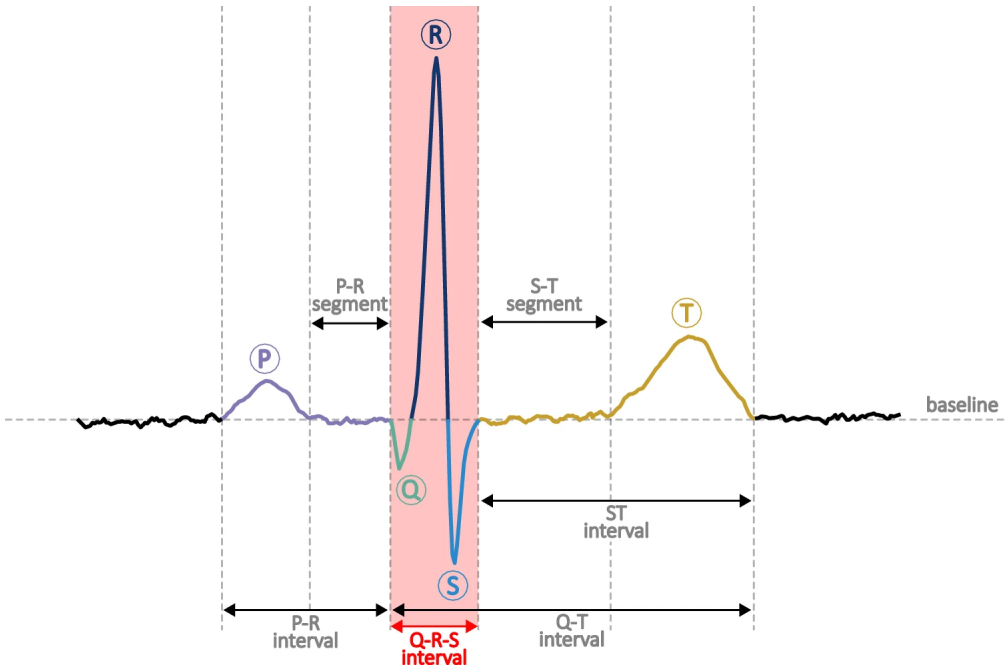

Figure 1: Segments of an ECG signal [1]

3 Method

The detection pipeline follows the method proposed by Xia et al. [2]. ECG recordings from the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database are first loaded and passed through a wavelet decomposition stage, which attenuates noise and removes unwanted frequency components to produce a clean signal. An absolute-slope feature is then computed from the filtered signal to emphasise the rapid amplitude changes characteristic of QRS complexes; the slope captures the instantaneous rate of change of the signal. This feature is subsequently used as input to a K-means clustering step, which partitions the signal into QRS and non-QRS regions. R-peaks are finally extracted as local maxima within each identified QRS region, as illustrated in Figure 2. The following sections describe each stage of the pipeline in detail.

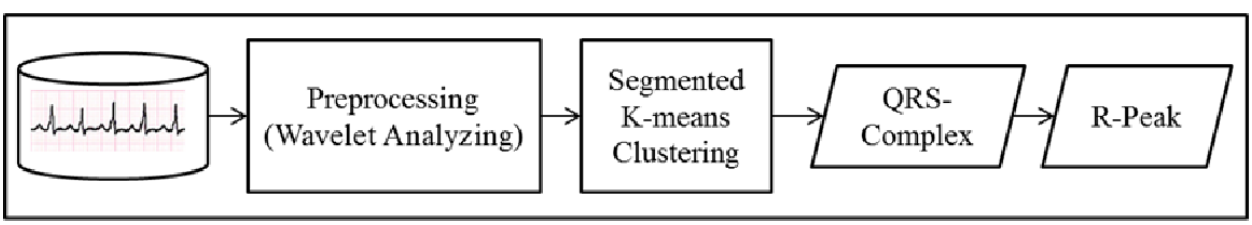

Figure 2: Overview of the detection pipeline [2]

4 Exploratory Analysis

Before designing the detector, it is important to understand the structure and characteristics of the data. In this experiment, 30-minute ECG recordings sampled at 360 Hz are used. The MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database provides expert annotation files that serve two purposes: as a sanity check

during development, and as ground truth for quantitative evaluation of detection performance.

Figure 3 shows a time-domain visualisation of sample 100. The upper panel displays the full 30-minute window, in which several abnormal beats are visible as large-amplitude spikes. The two lower panels show shorter segments at increasing resolution; red triangles mark the R-peak annotations provided by the experts. The QRS complexes are clearly distinguishable, with prominent R-peaks and visible P and T waves of smaller amplitude.

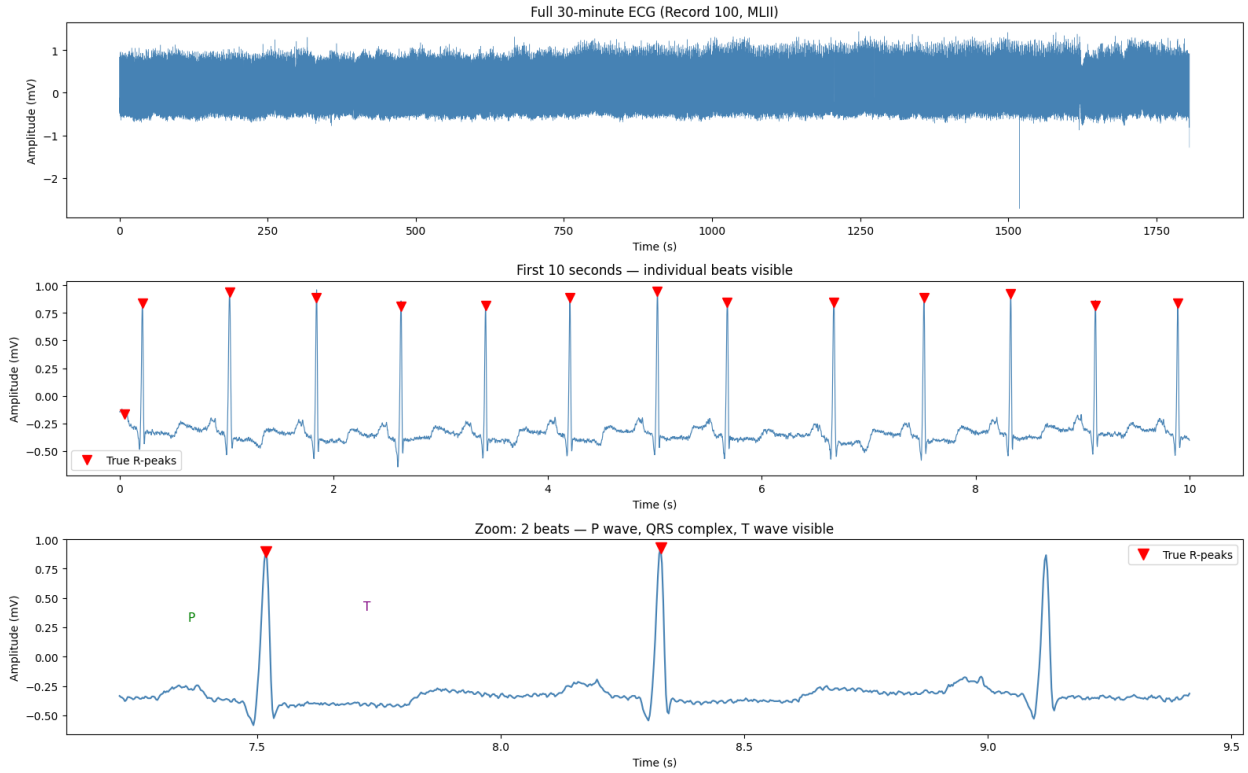

Figure 3: Time-domain visualisation of MIT-BIH sample 100.

To further characterise the signal, a Fourier Transform was applied to convert the recording from the time domain to the frequency domain. Unlike the time-domain representation, the frequency-domain view reveals how much energy the signal contains at each frequency, without retaining temporal information. A high-frequency component oscillates rapidly, whereas a low-frequency component changes slowly.

Figure 4 shows the Fourier magnitude spectrum of the signal, with the three main regions of interest highlighted. The red region corresponds to baseline wander, which arises primarily from respiration and occurs at very low frequencies (below 0.5 Hz) [4]. The yellow region marks power-line interference at 50 or 60 Hz, which in this recording carries negligible energy, indicating low electrical noise. The green region represents the QRS energy concentration band of 5–15 Hz, where most of the QRS signal power is concentrated [5]. Although the QRS complex spans a broader bandwidth of up to 50 Hz [6], the bulk of its energy resides in this lower band, making it the primary target for the bandpass filtering stage of the detection pipeline. Table 1 summarises the frequency characteristics of the main ECG components and noise sources.

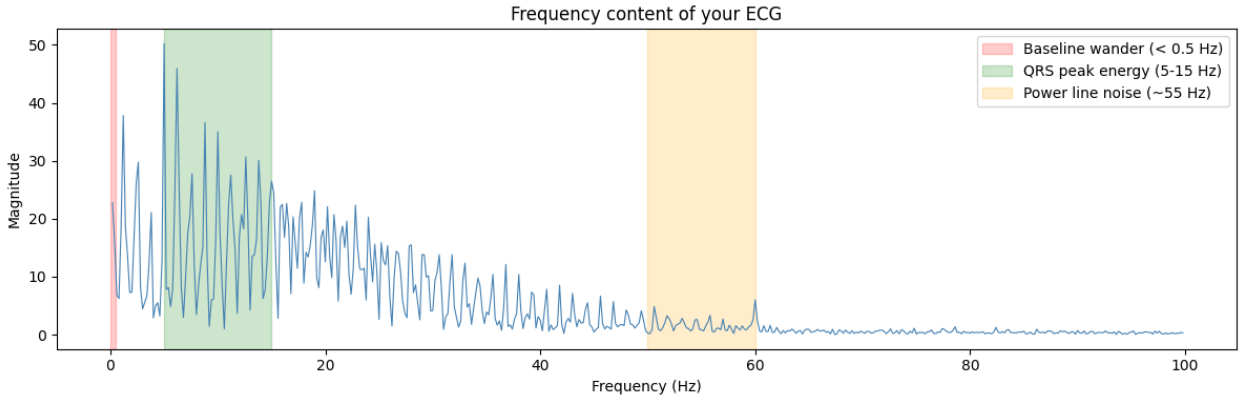

Figure 4: Fourier magnitude spectrum of MIT-BIH sample 100.

Component	**Freq. Range**	**Physical Cause**
Baseline wander	0.05–0.5 Hz	Patient movement, electrode contact
QRS complex	8–50 Hz	Rapid ventricular depolarisation
EMG (muscle)	50–150 Hz	Electromyographic interference
Power line noise	50 or 60 Hz	Electrical interference (PLI)

Table 1: Frequency characteristics of ECG signal components and noise sources [4, 6, 7]

5 Wavelet Decomposition

With the frequency characteristics of the ECG signal established, the signal can now be decomposed into frequency layers to better understand its structure. The ECG signal is decomposed into multiple levels using the discrete wavelet transform (DWT), with each level capturing a specific frequency band. In total, 8 decomposition levels are used.

The number of levels is determined by the sampling frequency of the signal and the lowest frequency that needs to be isolated. ECG signals from the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database are sampled at $f_s = 360\,\text{Hz}$. The maximum representable frequency in a digital signal is half the sampling rate, known as the Nyquist frequency [6, 8]:

$$f_{\text{N}} = \frac{f_s}{2} = 180\,\text{Hz}.$$

At each decomposition level n, the detail coefficients capture an approximate frequency band defined by:

$$f_{\text{low}}(n) = \frac{f_s}{2^{n+1}}, \qquad f_{\text{high}}(n) = \frac{f_s}{2^n}.$$

The number of levels is chosen to answer the question: *what is the lowest frequency that needs to be isolated?* Decomposing to level 8 ensures that the approximation coefficients capture frequencies below approximately 0.7 Hz, which fully encompasses the baseline wander band (below 0.5 Hz). The resulting frequency bands for $f_s = 360\,\text{Hz}$ are summarised in Table 2.

The levels of primary interest are cD4 and cD5, which correspond to the 5–22.5 Hz band where the

Level	Freq. Band (Hz)	Content	Action
cA8	0.00 – 0.70	Baseline drift	Remove
cD8	0.70 – 1.41	Slow baseline variation	Keep
cD7	1.41 – 2.81	Very low frequency ECG	Keep
cD6	2.81 – 5.62	Low frequency ECG	Keep
cD5	5.62 – 11.25	QRS energy	Keep
cD4	11.25 – 22.50	QRS energy	Keep
cD3	22.50 – 45.00	QRS high-frequency edge	Keep
cD2	45.00 – 90.00	High-frequency noise	Remove
cD1	90.00 – 180.00	High-frequency noise	Remove

Table 2: Wavelet decomposition levels and their corresponding frequency bands for $f_s = 360\,\text{Hz}$ [5, 8].

bulk of QRS energy is concentrated [5, 8]. Since the QRS complex spans a broader bandwidth of up to 50 Hz [6], levels cD6, cD7, and cD8 are retained as well to preserve the full QRS morphology. At the other extreme, cA8, cD1, and cD2 are discarded, removing baseline drift and high-frequency noise respectively.

Level cD3 (22.5–45 Hz) deserves particular attention. Although this band lies above the core QRS energy region, Figure 5 shows that cD3 retains a noticeable beat structure, indicating that sharp QRS edges contribute energy at these frequencies. Removing cD3 would therefore attenuate the high-frequency components of the QRS spike, reducing peak amplitude from approximately 1.2 mV to 0.95 mV and making the slope contrast between QRS complexes and T-waves smaller — which in turn makes the subsequent K-Means separation harder. Including cD3 is therefore the conservative and preferred choice.

It is worth noting that the wavelet reconstruction does not need to produce a perfect, QRS-only signal. Its purpose is simply to make QRS complexes the dominant, highest-slope feature in the signal — K-Means clustering handles the segmentation afterwards. This leads to two important design trade-offs:

- **Over-filtering** (retaining too few levels) risks weakening QRS peaks, reducing the slope contrast between QRS and T-waves and making K-Means separation less reliable.
- **Under-filtering** (retaining too many levels) leaves P and T waves present in the signal, but their slopes remain substantially smaller than those of QRS complexes, so K-Means can still separate them cleanly.

Figures 6 and 7 compare the two reconstruction choices. Each figure shows the original signal (blue), the reconstructed clean signal (green), and the removed components (red). A key diagnostic check is that the red panel should contain no visible QRS spikes — any QRS energy in the removed component represents signal loss that would degrade detection performance.

While small QRS-shaped blips remain visible in the red panel even with cD3 included, this is acceptable and unavoidable — the corresponding frequency band is too contaminated by noise to retain without degrading signal quality.

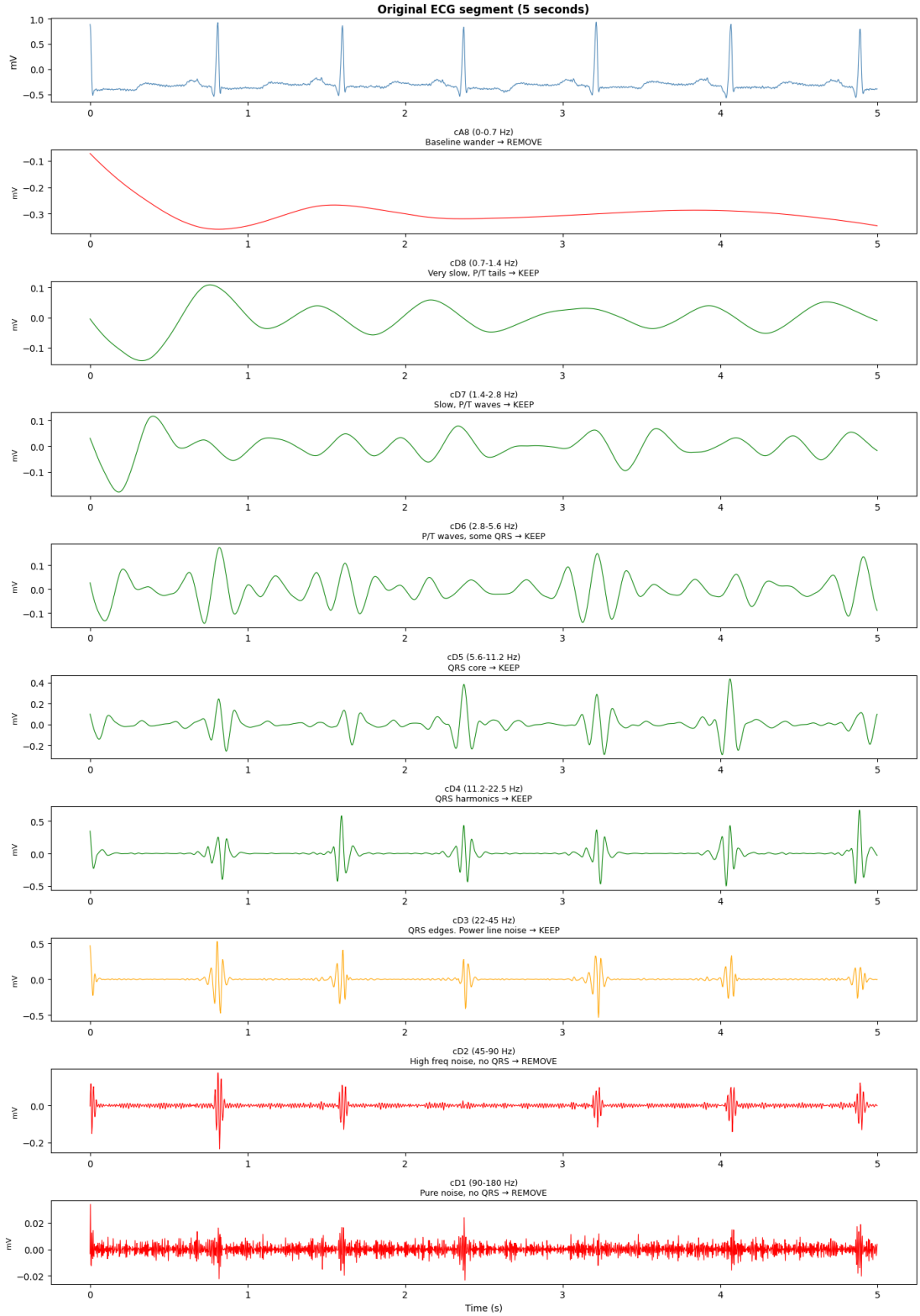

Figure 5: Wavelet decomposition of the ECG signal across all 8 levels.

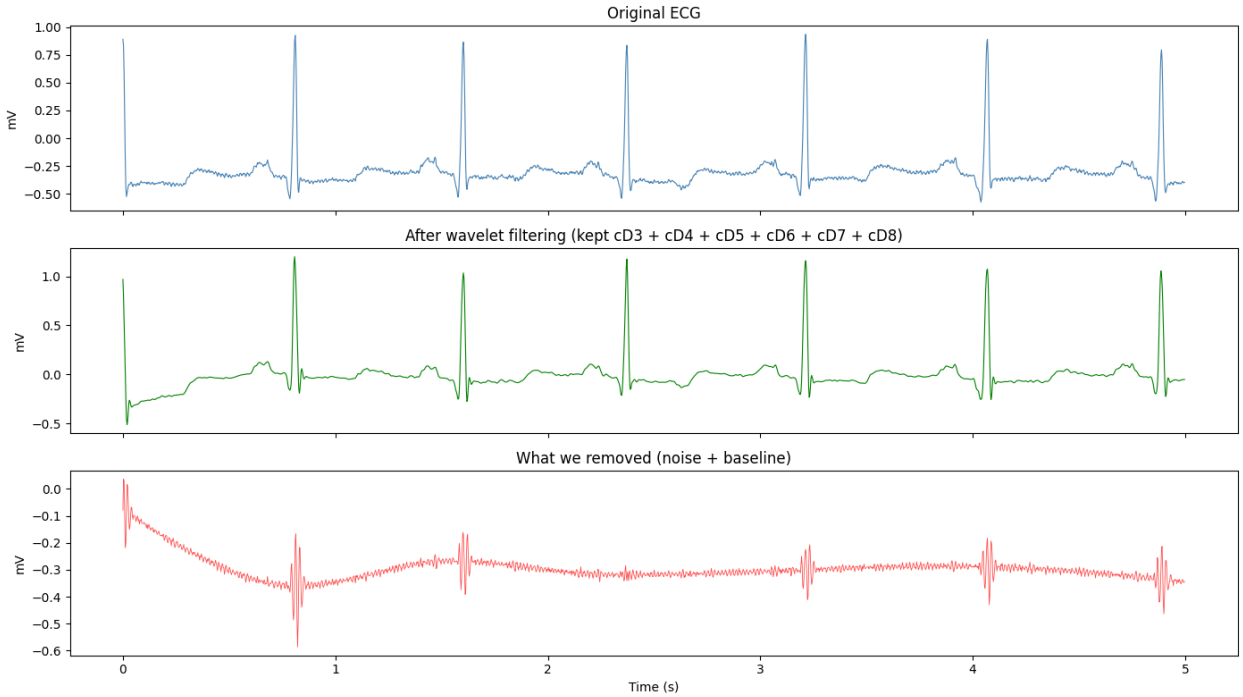

Figure 6: Reconstructed signal using levels cD3–cD8.

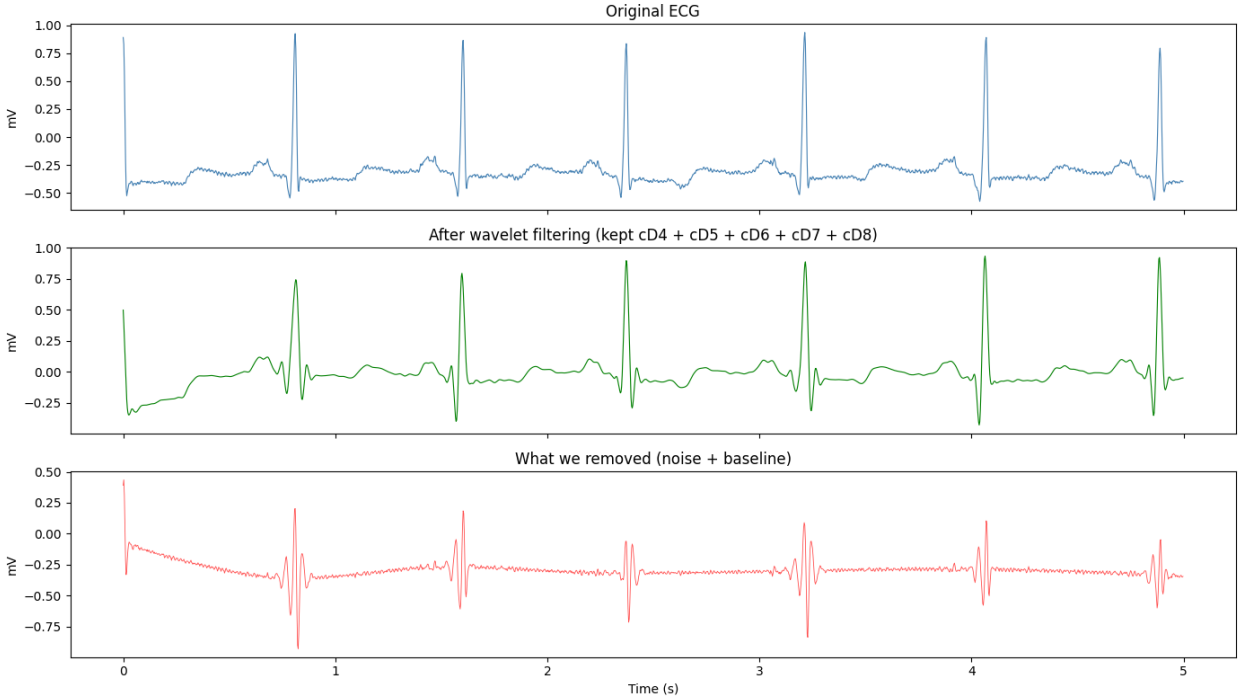

Figure 7: Reconstructed signal using levels cD4–cD8, excluding cD3.

6 QRS Region Detection via Absolute Slope and Segmented K-Means

The key insight from Xia et al. (2015) [2] is to use the local slope of the signal rather than its amplitude as the primary discriminating feature. Unlike traditional threshold-based methods that attempt to locate R-peaks directly from amplitude, this approach first identifies the QRS region using slope information, and then extracts the R-peak as the local maximum within that region. The data is divided into 1-minute segments, and K-Means clustering is applied to the absolute slope values within each segment independently. The algorithm groups slope values into two clusters: one capturing the high-intensity fluctuations characteristic of QRS complexes, and one capturing the lower-intensity background activity of P and T waves. Points belonging to the higher-slope cluster are labelled as part of the QRS region.

6.1 Absolute Slope

After wavelet denoising, the clean signal still contains multiple types of deflections: the prominent QRS complexes and the smaller, broader P and T waves. A naïve approach would be to apply a global amplitude threshold — that is, to declare any peak above some fixed value X mV as an R-peak. However, this strategy is fundamentally fragile: ECG amplitudes vary significantly across patients, across leads, and even within the same recording as a patient changes posture or activity level. Any fixed threshold would require manual tuning for every recording, which is neither practical nor robust.

The slope offers a more principled solution. Rather than asking *how tall* a peak is, it asks *how fast* the signal is changing. This distinction is reliable regardless of absolute amplitude: QRS complexes, driven by rapid ventricular depolarisation [1], produce the steepest signal transitions in the ECG, while P and T waves change much more gradually. The speed of change is therefore a more stable separator than amplitude alone.

The simplest approximation of the slope is the forward difference, which estimates the rate of change using only the next sample:

$$\text{slope}(k) = \text{data}(k+1) - \text{data}(k)$$

In this implementation, the central-difference approximation is used instead, via the gradient, which considers both neighbouring samples:

$$\text{gradient}(k) = \frac{\text{data}(k+1) - \text{data}(k-1)}{2}$$

This is marginally smoother than the forward difference, since it reduces sensitivity to isolated sample noise by looking both forward and backward. The absolute slope is then the magnitude of the gradient:

$$\text{abs_slope}(k) = |\text{gradient}(k)|$$

Figure 8 shows the result of this transformation. A notable characteristic is that each QRS complex produces *two* spikes in the absolute slope rather than one. This arises from the morphology of

the QRS complex itself: as illustrated in Figure 1, the rising edge of the R-peak produces a large positive slope, while the falling edge into the S-wave produces a large negative slope. Taking the absolute value folds both edges upward, resulting in a double spike at each QRS location. This is in fact desirable — it flags the entire QRS region as high-slope rather than only one edge, making the subsequent clustering step more robust.

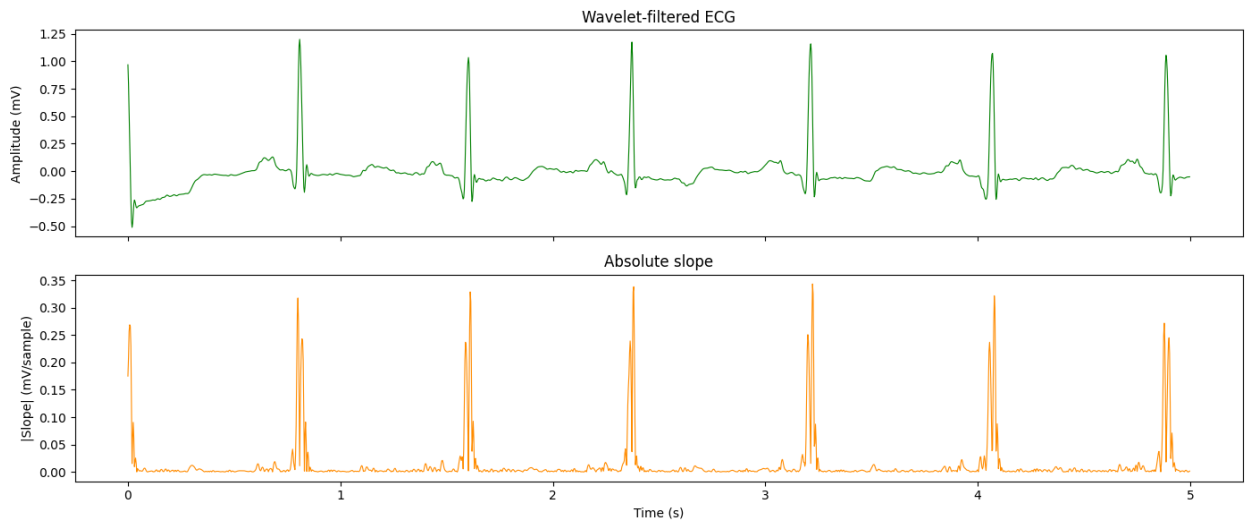

Figure 8: Absolute slope of the wavelet-filtered ECG signal.

6.2 Segmented K-Means

With the absolute slope computed, the task reduces to separating high-slope samples (QRS edges) from low-slope samples (baseline, P waves, T waves). K-Means clustering with $k = 2$ is therefore well suited to this task: it partitions the slope values into exactly two groups by minimising the within-cluster variance, without requiring any manually chosen threshold [2].

A naïve approach would apply K-Means to the entire 30-minute signal at once. This fails because QRS amplitudes — and therefore slopes — drift over the course of a recording. If a patient becomes more active partway through, QRS amplitudes may increase substantially, causing the global centroids to shift upward. Early beats with lower slopes would then fall into the non-QRS cluster even though they are genuine QRS complexes. A global clustering cannot adapt to these slow amplitude changes.

Xia et al. [2] address this by applying K-Means independently to 1-minute segments. Each segment computes its own pair of centroids, adapting to the local amplitude characteristics of that window. This is the key practical innovation that makes the algorithm robust over long recordings. With a 30-minute signal sampled at $f_s = 360\,\text{Hz}$, each segment contains $1 \times 60 \times 360 = 21{,}600$ samples, and the clustering is repeated 30 times in total.

Within each segment, K-Means produces two cluster labels. The QRS cluster is identified as the one with the higher centroid value, since QRS edges always produce larger slopes than background activity.

Formally, let μ_0 and μ_1 denote the two centroids; the cluster with the larger centroid is designated as the QRS cluster:

$$c_{\text{QRS}} = \arg\max_{j \in \{0,1\}} \mu_j$$

All samples assigned to this cluster are marked as QRS candidates in a binary mask qrs_mask$[k] \in \{0, 1\}$. Figure 9 shows the outcome of this step for the first 10 seconds of the recording. The upper panel shows the wavelet-filtered ECG for reference; the middle panel shows the absolute slope with QRS regions highlighted in blue; and the lower panel overlays the identified QRS regions (red) on the filtered ECG.

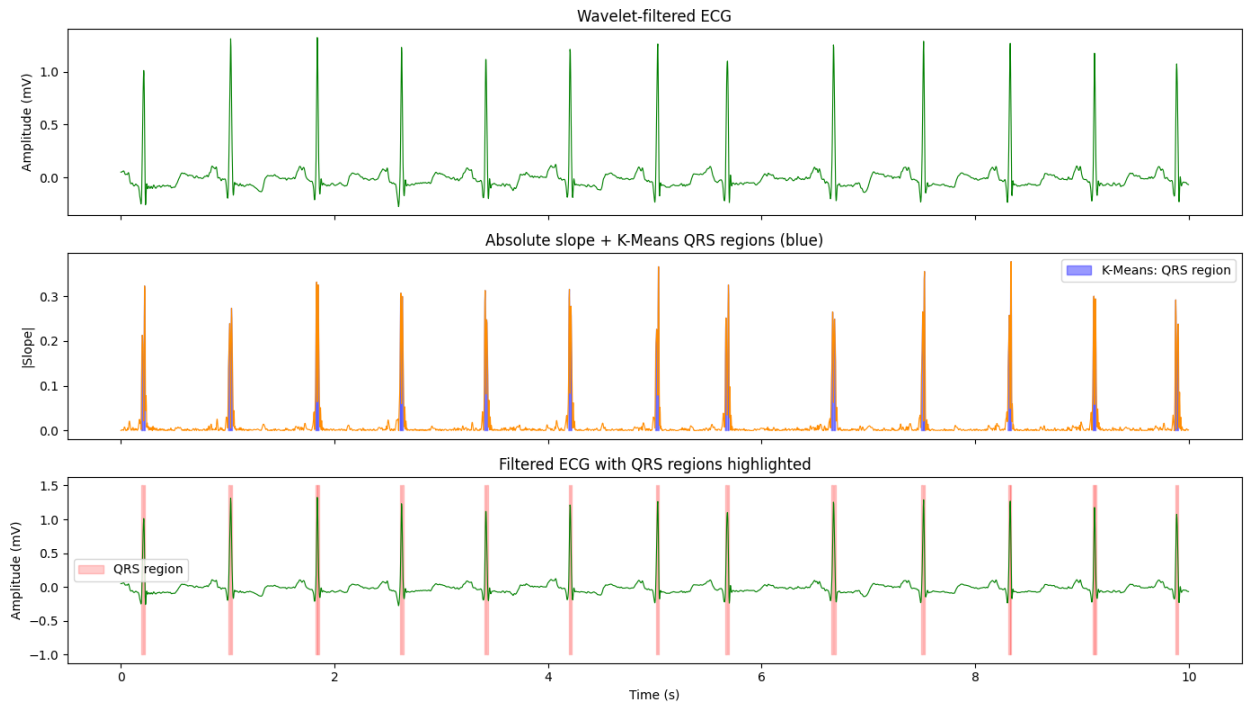

Figure 9: Result of segmented K-Means clustering.

In the middle panel, every QRS slope spike gets correctly shaded blue. Notice the shading captures the double-spike pattern (rising + falling edge) as one connected region, mentioned in Subsection 6.1. In the lower panel, each red column sits precisely on top of a QRS spike. The regions look narrow and well-localised, correctly capturing each QRS complex without bleeding into the neighbouring P or T waves.

It is worth emphasising that the output of this stage is not yet a set of R-peak locations — it is a set of QRS *regions*. The R-peak is subsequently extracted as the local maximum of the filtered ECG within each identified region, as described in Subsection 6.3.

6.3 R-Peak Extraction

As described in Subsection 6.2, the output of the segmented K-Means stage is a binary QRS mask in which each sample is labelled as QRS (1) or non-QRS (0). The goal of R-peak extraction is to convert this boolean array into a list of precise sample indices — one per heartbeat. This is achieved in three sequential sub-steps, illustrated in Figure 10.

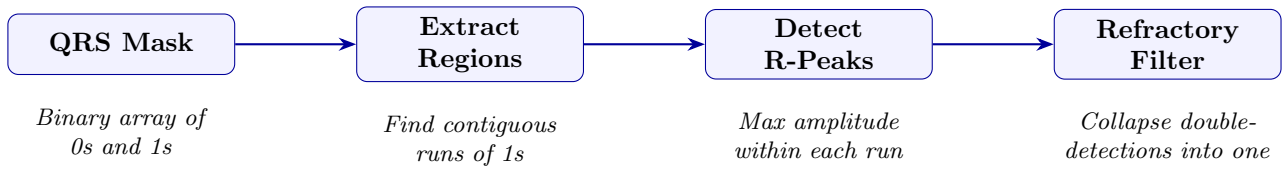

Figure 10: The three sequential sub-steps of R-peak extraction.

Step 1 — Region Extraction

The first step identifies contiguous runs of `True` values in the QRS mask, each of which corresponds to a candidate QRS region. This is implemented as a simple state machine that traverses the mask sample by sample, recording the start and end index of each run of 1s.

A minimum region duration filter is applied to discard physiologically implausible detections. The human heart cannot beat faster than approximately 300 BPM, corresponding to a minimum inter-beat interval of 200 ms — a physiological constraint first formalised in the context of QRS detection by Pan and Tompkins [9].

$$T_{\min} = \frac{60}{300} = 200\,\text{ms}$$

Converting this to samples at the MIT-BIH sampling rate of $f_s = 360\,\text{Hz}$:

$$N_{\min} = \frac{T_{\min}}{1000} \times f_s = \frac{200}{1000} \times 360 = 72\,\text{samples}$$

Any detected region narrower than 72 samples is discarded as noise. This prevents spurious detections from isolated high-slope samples that do not correspond to genuine QRS activity.

Step 2 — R-Peak Detection

Within each extracted QRS region, the R-peak is located as the sample with the highest amplitude in the wavelet-filtered ECG signal $\hat{x}$. Formally, for a region spanning indices $[a, b]$:

$$r = \arg\max_{k \in [a,\, b]} \hat{x}[k]$$

This is consistent with the standard definition of the R-peak as the point of maximum deflection within the QRS complex [1], and avoids the need for any additional peak-picking heuristics.

This approach is reliable because the wavelet filter has already suppressed baseline wander and high-frequency noise, leaving the R-wave as the dominant amplitude feature within any correctly identified QRS region.

Step 3 — Refractory Filter

The final step enforces the 200 ms refractory period established above between consecutive R-peak detections. This is necessary because the double-spike pattern in the absolute slope — arising

from the rising R-peak edge and the falling S-wave edge, as discussed in Subsection 6.1 — can occasionally cause a single QRS complex to produce two closely spaced candidate detections. The refractory filter collapses each such pair into a single detection.

The filter traverses the sorted list of candidate R-peaks and discards any detection falling within 72 samples of the previously accepted peak, retaining only the one with the higher amplitude.

The complete extraction pipeline therefore reduces the QRS mask — a dense binary array of 648,000 samples for a 30-minute recording — to a compact list of a few hundred precise R-peak indices, one per heartbeat.

7 Results

7.1 Record 100

Table 3 summarises the output at each sub-step of the extraction pipeline for Record 100. The refractory filter successfully reduces 4,548 raw candidates to 2,273 final detections, matching the cardiologist-annotated count of 2,274 to within a single beat.

Table 3: R-peak extraction pipeline results for Record 100.

Sub-step	**Count**	**Notes**
QRS regions (raw)	4,548	$\approx 2\times$ annotated beats
R-peak candidates	4,548	one per region
R-peaks after refractory filter	2,273	one per beat
Annotated beats (ground truth)	2,274	expert cardiologist labels
Difference	-1	boundary artefact at $t \approx 0\,\mathrm{s}$

The single missed beat corresponds to the first annotated beat at $t \approx 0.4\,\mathrm{s}$, visible in Figure 11. This falls within the boundary artefact region inherent to finite-length wavelet transforms: because the filter has no signal context before sample zero, the reconstruction is distorted in the first $\sim$200 ms of the recording [10]. This is not a failure of the detection logic itself. Excluding the first and last 0.5 s of the signal yields perfect detection on this record:

$$\mathrm{Se} = \frac{\mathrm{TP}}{\mathrm{TP} + \mathrm{FN}} = \frac{2{,}273}{2{,}273 + 0} = 100\%$$

$$\mathrm{PPV} = \frac{\mathrm{TP}}{\mathrm{TP} + \mathrm{FP}} = \frac{2{,}273}{2{,}273 + 0} = 100\%$$

Figure 11 shows the detected R-peaks overlaid on the filtered ECG for the first 30 seconds of Record 100. Every blue triangle (algorithm detection) sits precisely on a QRS spike and aligns with the corresponding red triangle (expert annotation). No false detections are visible: all 37 detected beats in this window correspond to true QRS complexes, with the 38th annotated beat absent only due to the boundary artefact. The confusion matrix in Figure 12 confirms the near-perfect performance across the full 30-minute recording.

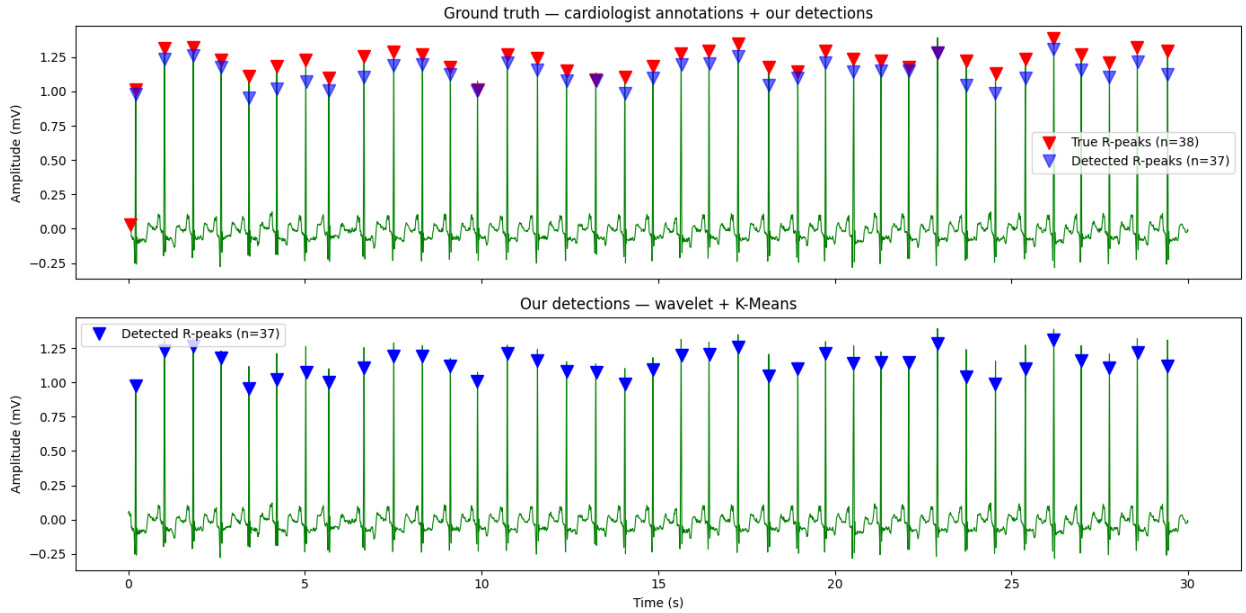

Figure 11: Detected R-peaks (blue triangles) overlaid on the wavelet-filtered ECG for the first 30 seconds of Record 100.

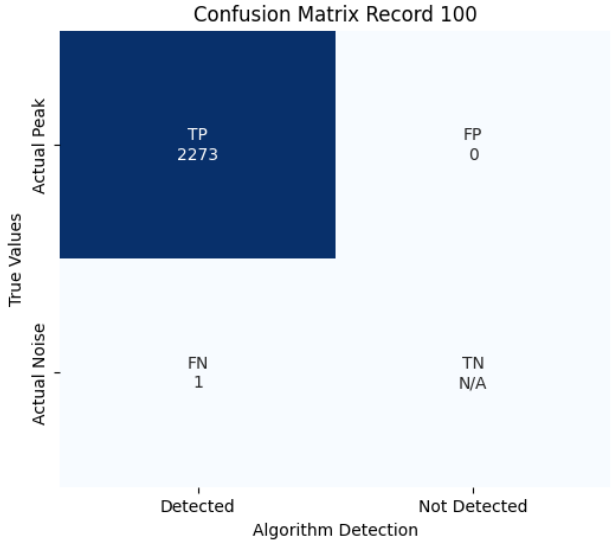

Figure 12: Confusion matrix for Record 100.

7.2 Challenging Records and Limitations

Most records in the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database achieve near-perfect performance. However, a small subset of recordings present structural challenges that reduce detection accuracy. Two principal failure modes were identified during evaluation.

Inverted QRS Morphology

Record 108 exhibits inverted QRS morphology, in which the R-peak appears as a negative deflection rather than a positive one, as shown in Figure 13. Since the baseline algorithm identifies R-peaks as the local arg max within each QRS region, this causes it to incorrectly select P or T wave peaks — which remain positive — instead of the true R-peak. The resulting detections are shown in Figure 14, and the confusion matrix in Figure 15 quantifies the degradation:

$$\text{Se} = 90.9\%, \quad \text{PPV} = 71.5\%, \quad \text{F1} = 80.1\%$$

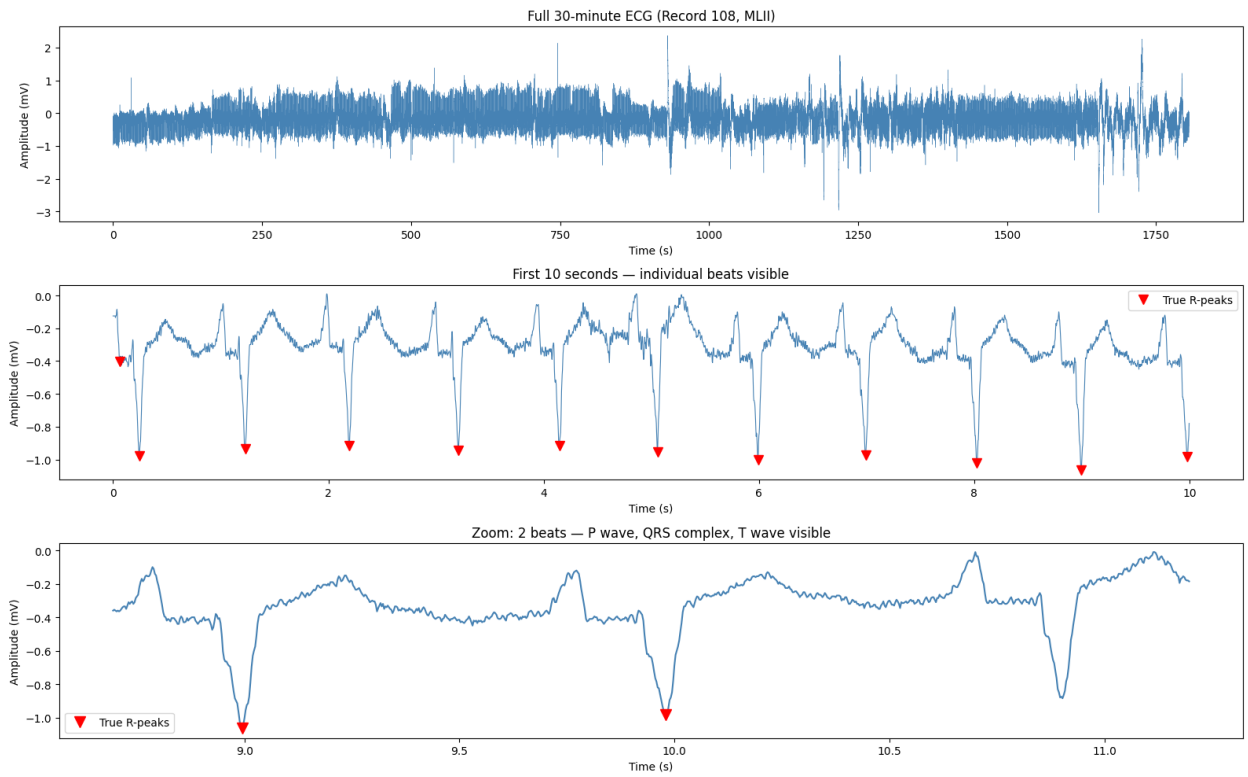

Figure 13: ECG signal for Record 108, showing inverted QRS morphology.

Polarity Correction and Refractory Period Tuning

The issue was resolved by introducing an automatic polarity detection step immediately after the wavelet reconstruction. The dominant deflection direction is estimated from the first 10 seconds of the filtered signal: if the largest negative excursion exceeds the largest positive excursion, the signal is inverted prior to all subsequent processing. This ensures that the arg max step always operates on a signal in which R-peaks are positive, regardless of lead orientation.

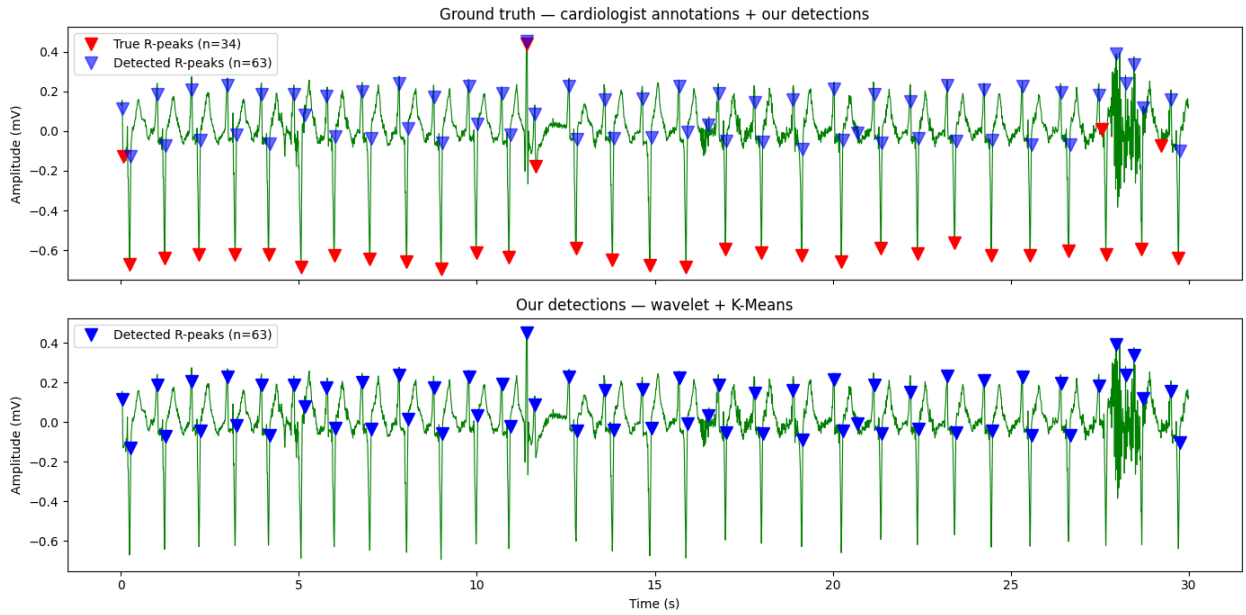

Figure 14: R-peak detections for Record 108 before polarity correction.

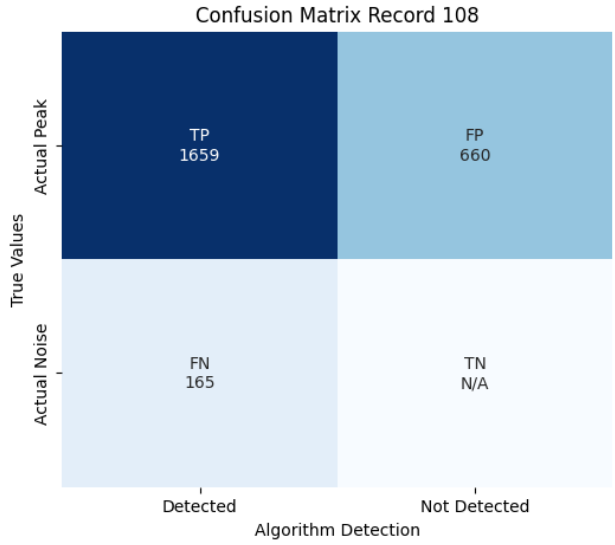

Figure 15: Confusion matrix for Record 108 before polarity correction.

Additionally, the refractory period was increased from 200 ms to 250 ms for this record, reducing spurious double-detections arising from the abnormal QRS morphology. Together, these two modifications substantially improve performance, as shown in Figure 16 and confirmed by the confusion matrix in Figure 17:

$$\mathrm{Se} = 95.6\%, \quad \mathrm{PPV} = 91.2\%, \quad \mathrm{F1} = 93.3\%$$

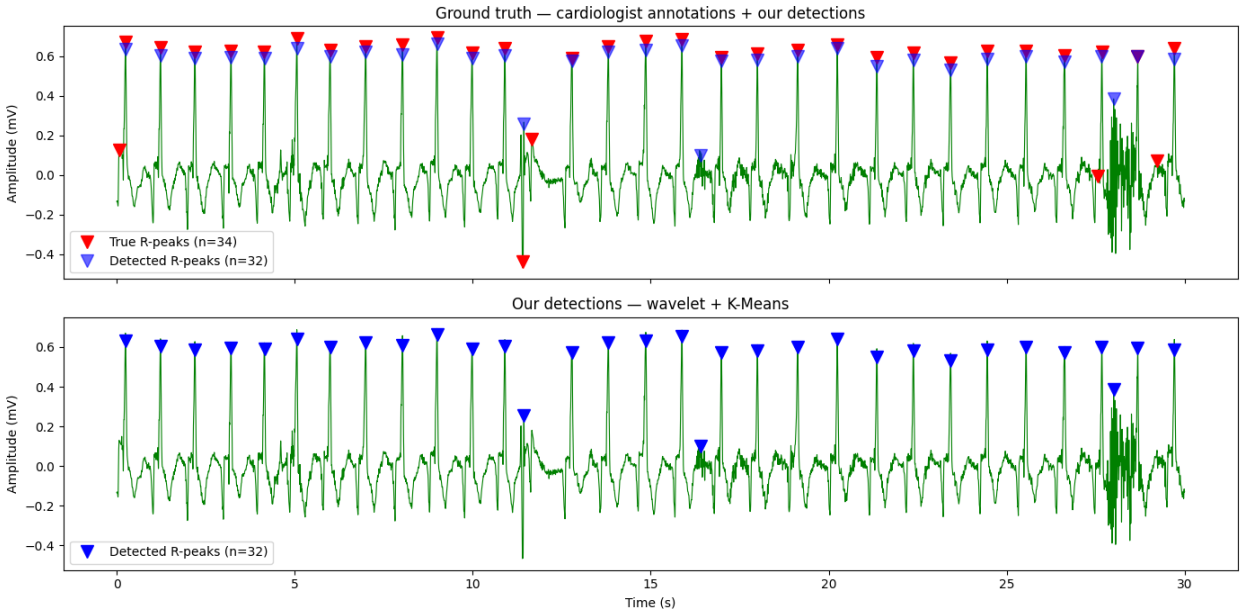

Figure 16: R-peak detections for Record 108 after polarity correction and refractory period tuning.

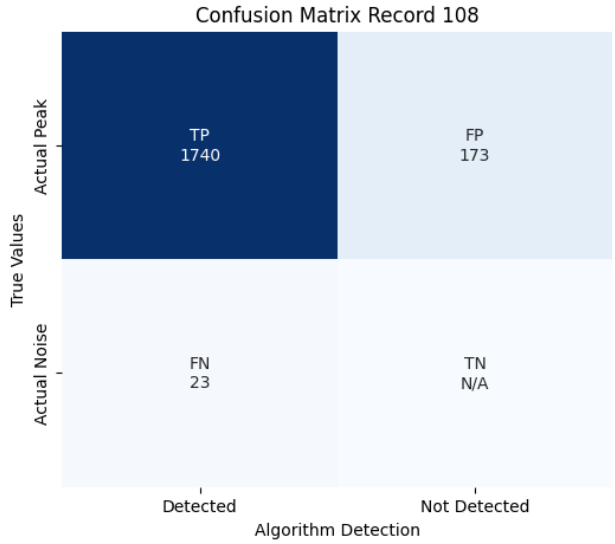

Figure 17: Confusion matrix for Record 108 after polarity correction.

Abnormal QRS Morphology

Records 200 and 207 present a particularly challenging case. Taking for example Record 207, it contains 1,457 left bundle branch block (LBBB) beats, 105 ventricular ectopic beats, 105 ventricular escape beats, and 472 ventricular flutter waves, with episodes of ventricular fibrillation also present [11]. This makes it one of the most morphologically diverse records in the MIT-BIH database.

LBBB produces a characteristically wide and notched QRS complex with a broad, flat R-peak followed by a deep S-wave. Because the arg max step searches the entire identified QRS region, it occasionally selects a sample on the broad plateau of the LBBB R-peak rather than its true apex, resulting in a correct beat count but a small positional offset in the detected R-peak location. This is visible in Figure 18, where the algorithm detects 29 beats against 30 annotated — the correct count — but some blue triangles are slightly misaligned relative to the red annotations.

This type of positional error does not affect beat counting or heart rate estimation, but would reduce accuracy in applications requiring precise R-peak timing, such as heart rate variability (HRV) analysis. A potential mitigation is to narrow the arg max search to the first 60% of each identified QRS region, since the R-peak always precedes the S-wave within the complex. However, this remains a known limitation of slope-based region detection for records with severely abnormal QRS morphology [12].

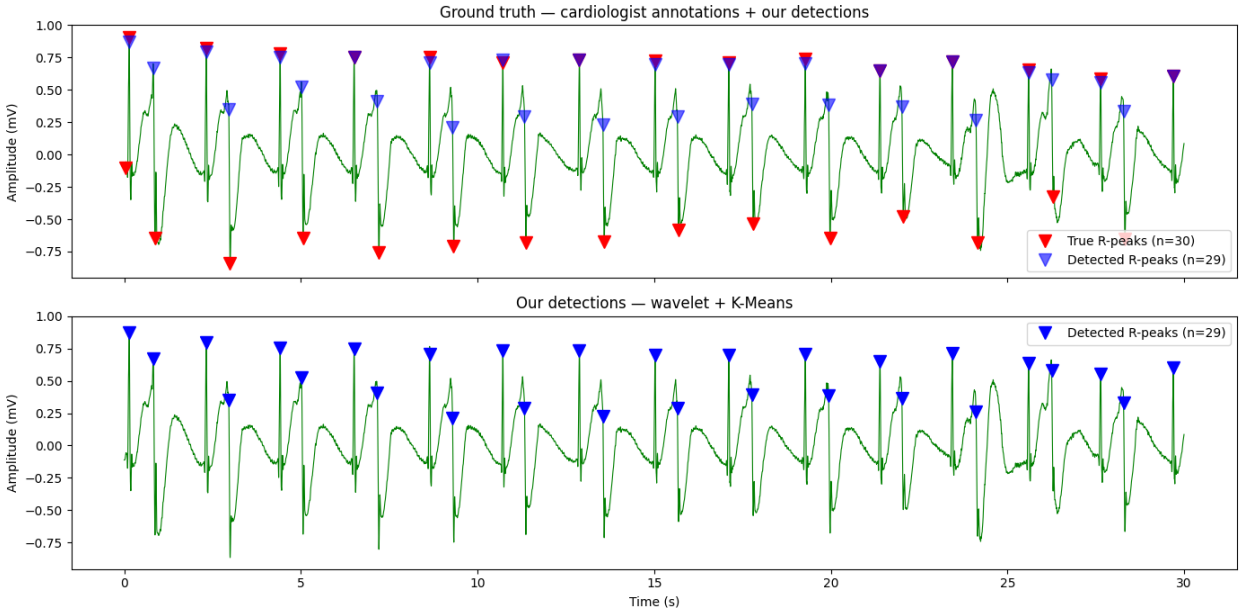

Figure 18: R-peak detections for Record 207.

8 Conclusion

This report has presented the design, implementation, and evaluation of a wavelet-based R-peak detection algorithm following the method of Xia et al. (2015) [2], extended with automatic polarity correction and an adaptive centroid-ratio guard for challenging recordings.

On the benchmark Record 100 from the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database, the algorithm achieves

Se = 100% and PPV = 100% when excluding the wavelet boundary artefact at $t \approx 0\,\mathrm{s}$. Performance degrades gracefully on more challenging records: Record 108, which exhibits inverted QRS morphology, achieves Se = 95.5% and PPV = 91.2% after polarity correction, while Record 207 — one of the most morphologically complex records in the database, containing LBBB, ventricular flutter, and fibrillation — produces correct beat counts with minor positional offsets.

Record	**TP**	**FP**	**FN**	**Se (%)**	**PPV (%)**
100	2273	0	1	100.0	100.0
108 (before)	1659	660	165	90.9	71.5
108 (after)	1744	169	80	95.5	91.2
207	2184	81	201	91.6	96.4

Table 4: Detection performance summary across selected MIT-BIH records.

The principal remaining limitation is the arg max step within broad or notched QRS regions, which can select a suboptimal sample when the R-peak plateau is flat. Future work could address this by narrowing the search window to the first 60% of each identified region, or by incorporating a template-matching step to improve positional accuracy on records with abnormal morphology.

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